New Resident Checklist

A first-month planning list for North Port & Venice, Florida

Confirm every item with the official office named here. This is a planning list, not government, tax, or legal advice. Deadlines, fees, and forms change. Full guides: https://tolmondh.github.io/np-venice-move/guides/

Utilities & trash

Who you call depends on the exact address — inside the City of North Port, inside the City of Venice, or unincorporated Sarasota County. Confirm on the city or county site; don't use old phone numbers from blogs.

- [ ] Start electric service with your move-in date. Florida Power & Light (FPL) is common in this area; confirm for your address.
- [ ] Start water and sewer with the utility that serves the parcel (City of North Port, City of Venice, or a Sarasota County district).
- [ ] Find out who collects trash, recycling, and yard waste, whether carts stay with the house, the set-out time, and the pickup day.
- [ ] Ask whether a deposit or credit check is required, and save account numbers and autopay logins the week you move.
- [ ] Official starting points: northportfl.gov, venicegov.com, and scgov.net. More detail: the Utilities & trash and Trash, recycling & yard waste guides on the site.

Florida driver license & vehicle registration

Once you establish residency, two clocks start. Rules come from the Florida Department of Highway Safety and Motor Vehicles (FLHSMV). Local service is through the Sarasota County Tax Collector.

- [ ] Get a Florida driver license or Florida ID card within 30 days of establishing residency (FLHSMV).
- [ ] Title and register your out-of-state vehicle in Florida within 10 days of starting work, enrolling children in public school, or establishing residency (FLHSMV). You will need Florida auto insurance first.
- [ ] Book a Tax Collector appointment. Appointments are recommended for all services and are required for tests and for any service at the North Port office. Schedule at sarasotataxcollector.gov or call 941-861-8300.
- [ ] Bring the identity, Social Security, address, title, and insurance documents listed on FLHSMV's "What to Bring" and new-resident pages. Cancel out-of-state plates and insurance only after the Florida plate and policy are active.
- [ ] Official sources: flhsmv.gov and sarasotataxcollector.gov.

Voter registration & address update

If you choose to register (or you are already a Florida voter), your record needs your new Sarasota County address. North Port and Venice are both in Sarasota County.

- [ ] Register or update your address with the Sarasota County Supervisor of Elections. You can do this online at RegisterToVoteFlorida.gov, at a Tax Collector office when you get your Florida license or ID, or with Form DS-DE 39 by mail or in person.
- [ ] The deadline to register for an upcoming election is 29 days before that election. The same 29-day deadline applies to changing party before a primary. Florida has closed primaries.
- [ ] Florida does not move your old state's registration for you. After you register here, contact your previous state or county election office about canceling the old record.
- [ ] Official sources: RegisterToVoteFlorida.gov and the Sarasota County Supervisor of Elections.

Homestead exemption (if you bought a home and will live there)

Florida's homestead exemption is not automatic. You have to apply. Timing and documents are set by Florida law and administered by the Sarasota County Property Appraiser (sc-pa.com).

- ☐ To qualify for a given year, you must be a Florida resident and own and occupy the home as your permanent residence on January 1 of that year. If you close later in the year, you are generally applying for the following year.
- ☐ File a timely application by March 1. The Property Appraiser says it will still consider later filings, but do not count on a late filing.
- ☐ A valid Florida driver license or Florida ID card showing the permanent residence address is listed as required. A "Valid in Florida Only" license or ID is not acceptable. Start the license step early — it often takes the longest for out-of-state movers.
- ☐ Gather proof of ownership (usually the recorded deed), additional proof of permanent residence (such as Florida voter registration at the address), Social Security numbers (required by Florida law; married applicants must provide information for both spouses), and proof that any exemption on a previous home was canceled or that the prior home was sold.
- ☐ Apply online and check status at sc-pa.com. The exemption does not carry over from the seller; you file your own application.

Library card

Sarasota County Libraries and Historical Resources issues one card that works at every county branch, including North Port and Venice, plus digital resources once your account is approved.

- ☐ Apply online (resident applications are verified through a third party) or in person at any county library with a photo ID and proof of a current Sarasota County address.
- ☐ A Florida driver license or Florida ID that already shows your current Sarasota County address can serve as both ID and proof of address. Otherwise bring a photo ID plus a residency document such as a current lease, utility bill, vehicle registration, property tax bill, or voter registration card — confirm the current list on the county library FAQ.
- ☐ If you do not yet qualify as a resident (for example, you are a seasonal visitor), the library offers paid non-resident cards. Confirm current fees with the library before you pay.
- ☐ Official starting point: the Sarasota County Libraries "How do I get a library card?" FAQ, or call Info Central at 941-861-1110.

Hurricane prep

NOAA's official Atlantic hurricane season runs from June 1 through November 30. Build basics in your first month — do not wait for a named storm in the Gulf. Follow the National Weather Service and county emergency management for live orders.

- ☐ Look up the flood zone and evacuation level for your exact address (county maps on scgov.net), not just the city name.
- ☐ Know where you would go if told to evacuate (a friend inland, a hotel plan, or shelter information from the county).
- ☐ Photograph important documents and keep copies in the cloud and in a waterproof bag.
- ☐ Stock water, medications, flashlights, power banks, and pet supplies before shelves empty.
- ☐ Ask your HOA or landlord about shutter rules and generator restrictions.
- ☐ Confirm homeowners or renters coverage and whether flood coverage is separate. Official sources: noaa.gov (season dates) and scgov.net (county emergency information).

Get updates when official rules change

Join the free NP & Venice Move Notes newsletter, then keep this PDF handy. Full guides, official links, and the latest version of this checklist: https://tolmondh.github.io/np-venice-move/downloads/new-resident-checklist.html

Newsletter: https://tolmonds-newsletter.beehiiv.com/subscribe

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